

PARENT TIPS

Encouraging independence

- Set achievable goals, and reward your teen by giving a bit more independence every time they succeed.
- Understand what your teen hopes to gain. By knowing this, you can focus on building independence in these areas.
- Acknowledge when things go well, and reflect with your teen when they don't. Accept responsibility if you didn't make the right call.
- Teens may want input into family decisions. Show you value their contribution by asking for their opinion.
- As teens grow, let them make their own choices, but if things go wrong, they should face the consequences.

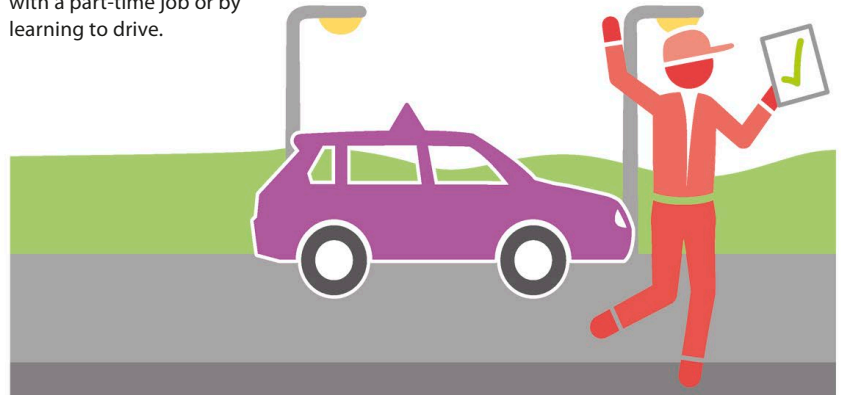
Independence

All teens strive to become more independent. To feel in charge of their lives and able to make decisions makes them less likely to push boundaries and feel held back. Naturally, many parents feel apprehensive about this, but it is important to allow teens opportunities, and to celebrate their successes, too.

Through small, incremental steps toward an agreed goal, teens can be guided in developing independence. Setbacks are inevitable, but discussions about what might help next time will ensure realistic expectations.

▽ **It takes time**

Teens gain independence as they get older, perhaps with a part-time job or by learning to drive.

**Privacy**

Everyone wants and needs some level of privacy. For teens, wanting to be private is all part of growing up. Teen privacy could mean having a lock on a bedroom door or having time alone each day away from family life. Every teen and family has different boundaries, but clear rules relating to personal space will help avoid unnecessary problems.

If parents are concerned about their teen's well-being, they may feel the need to invade their privacy—for example, by reading their text messages. However, this should not be done without permission—invading someone's privacy may violate their trust and damage the relationship.

▷ **Teen bedrooms**

A messy teen bedroom can be irritating for parents, but acknowledging that it is a teen's personal space allows them to feel that their privacy is respected.

GOOD TO KNOW

Privacy and secrecy

A teen's desire for privacy does not mean that they have something to hide or that they are avoiding the family. A teen needs time alone during adolescence to develop their identity and figure out who they are.

